

check for scratches, and always opt for a branded CD. When you make a tar file, check for the integrity of the file by uncompressing it into a folder and checking the contents. If the data is very important, back it up on two CDs.

3.2.2.1 Creating a Rescue Disk

During a crisis, a rescue disks can help you prevent a potential format/reinstall. Rescue disks can be got off the Net or created from within the OS itself. Floppies are now hardly being used as rescue disks owing to their limited size and unreliability. You can get .iso files online and burn the image on to a CD. Keep the CD handy. The rescue disk boots into a command prompt where you can type in “help” and press [Enter] to get the list of available commands.

3.3 Single User Mode

When things go wrong...

A robust rescue option in Unix and its derivatives, including Linux, is Single User Mode, where only the system administrator (root) account can log in, and only a few services are run (think of it as something like Windows' Safe Mode). Some administrative operations can only be done in Single User mode: for example, unmounting a user partition, since this is obviously not possible when a user is logged on. Another example is the fsck command on a user partition whose file system is corrupted. The fsck command works on raw data and not on partitions that are mounted. The root alone is mounted when in single user mode and there are no network connections available.

3.3.1 Entering Single User mode:

It is fairly simple to start Single User mode in Linux. All you have to do is make a small change in the boot loader. Most distributions now use Grub as a boot manager / loader. Here's how you can edit grub to start Single User mode:

1. When Grub appears with the OS choices menu, select Linux and hit [E] to edit the boot options.